

UPSC Civil Services (Main) Simulation GS-IV

DETAILED SOLUTIONS / ANSWER KEY | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

Q1. (a) "One who is devoted to one's duty attains highest perfection in life." Analyse this statement with reference to sense of responsibility and personal fulfilment as a civil servant. (b) Distinguish aptitude, attitude and value as objects of civil-service assessment. Illustrate each with one administrative example.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (285 words; practice model, not official): (a) Devotion to duty gives a civil servant purpose, reliability and satisfaction from advancing public welfare. It means competent, timely and impartial discharge of entrusted responsibility, not obedience to every informal demand or pursuit of visible targets at any cost. A disaster officer who remains accessible, protects vulnerable citizens, coordinates teams and records fair allocation decisions may experience fulfilment through meaningful service. Yet duty must be constitutional and sustainable: blind obedience can enable illegality, while relentless self-sacrifice can impair judgment, health and legitimate family obligations. In a personal emergency, responsible delegation and transparent communication may better serve citizens than either abandonment of duty or performative self-denial. Personal fulfilment is deepest when commitment joins integrity, empathy, lawful discretion, professional competence and accountable institutional support. It is the satisfaction of serving a public purpose well, not a claim to moral superiority over citizens or colleagues. (b) Aptitude, attitude and value are three distinct objects of assessment. Aptitude is the capacity to perform: a trainee's ability to manage a flood-control room tests aptitude. Attitude is an evaluative stance toward a specific object: an officer's enthusiasm for digital governance reflects her attitude toward technology, which may not generalise to other domains. Value is a cross-situational standard: integrity governs conduct across procurement, citizen interaction and personal finances. Confusing them weakens answers. Saying integrity is an attitude reduces a general moral standard to a domain-specific preference. Saying aptitude is fixed ignores that contemporary civil-service pedagogy, including Mission Karmayogi's competency-based training, treats aptitude as cultivable through deliberate practice. The administrative implication is that recruitment tests primarily measure aptitude and intelligence, while probation and performance review assess dedication and initiative. The verdict is that precise classification strengthens both assessment design and answer writing.

Q2. (a) "In doing a good thing, everything is permitted which is not prohibited expressly or by clear implication." Examine the statement with suitable examples in the context of a public servant discharging his/her duties. (b) Critically examine from the ethical point of view the proposition that Artificial Intelligence can serve as a dependable input for rational administrative decision-making.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (265 words; practice model, not official): (a) The statement rightly warns against administrative paralysis: law cannot anticipate every contingency, and a public servant may need initiative to deliver relief. During a flood, an authorised officer may choose an unlisted but lawful transport arrangement when delay would endanger life, recording necessity and later review. However, absence of an express prohibition is not unlimited permission. Public power differs from private liberty: the official also needs legal competence, authorised purpose, equality, proportionality, financial propriety and respect for rights. A collector cannot transfer public land to a favoured charity merely because no sentence expressly names that transaction. Nor may a welfare objective justify unauthorised disclosure of personal data. A Code of Conduct supplies the legal and procedural floor; a Code of Ethics tests purpose, fairness, selflessness and foreseeable harm where wording leaves space. (b) AI can improve administrative consistency, pattern detection, speed and evidence use, supporting consequentialist goals of better service delivery and risk reduction. It is not an ethically self-sufficient or invariably dependable source. Biased data may reproduce exclusion; opaque outputs obstruct reasons and appeal; automation can dilute accountability and treat citizens as data points rather than persons with dignity. A deontological floor requires legality, equality, privacy, due process and human responsibility. Consequence analysis should test false positives, distributional harm and long-term trust, not efficiency alone. Virtue ethics adds phronesis: an experienced official must know when to rely on, question or override an output. Therefore AI should be an auditable input under human oversight, with explainability, bias testing, grievance redressal and a named accountable authority; final moral responsibility cannot be delegated to the model.

Q3. (a) Distinguish between "Code of ethics" and "Code of conduct" with suitable examples. (b) 'International aid' is an accepted form of helping 'resource-challenged' nations. Comment on 'ethics in contemporary international aid'. Support your answer with suitable examples.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (268 words; practice model, not official): (a) A Code of Ethics states broad values and decision principles that persons in a role should aspire to embody: selflessness, integrity, impartiality, openness, accountability and service. It guides intention and

judgment when no detailed rule resolves the case. A Code of Conduct converts recurring risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences: declare a material interest, refuse or report specified gifts, protect official information, avoid partisan activity and file property returns. Thus an ethics code asks, 'What kind of public servant and public institution should we be?' A conduct code asks, 'What must or must not be done, by whom, through which process, and with what consequence?' The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 are an enforceable conduct framework. The Second ARC recommended comprehensive public-service values and a Code of Ethics as their complement. (b) International aid expresses solidarity and can protect life, health and development capabilities where domestic resources are inadequate. Its ethics, however, depends on design. Recipient ownership requires local institutions and communities to shape priorities; otherwise assistance becomes paternalistic. Conditions may safeguard rights and honest use, but unrelated commercial or geopolitical demands compromise sovereignty. Accountability is dual: donors must disburse predictably, avoid tied procurement and disclose interests; recipients must prevent diversion and report results. Food aid that permanently undercuts local farmers can create dependency, whereas time-bound nutrition support linked to local procurement and agricultural capacity protects immediate life while building autonomy. Humanitarian relief should follow need, neutrality and impartiality rather than political alignment. Aid is therefore ethical when it is transparent, participatory, proportionate, corruption-resistant and designed for durable local capacity and an exit path.

Q4. (a) "Judge your success by what you had to give up in order to get it." - Dalai Lama. What does this quotation mean to you? (b) An aspirational Code of Ethics is necessary but cannot be treated as a legally self-executing disciplinary code. Explain.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (254 words; practice model, not official): (a) The quotation proposes an ethical rather than merely numerical measure of success. Achievement should be assessed not only by targets reached but also by the values, relationships, rights and long-term capacities preserved or sacrificed during the process. A district may clear an infrastructure corridor before deadline by suppressing hearings, underpaying displaced families and intimidating dissent. The output indicator records success, but Kantian dignity, Rawlsian fairness and procedural justice reveal moral failure. Conversely, giving up personal comfort, popularity or promotion to defend lawful rehabilitation may enhance the ethical quality of the achievement. Sacrifice itself is not automatically noble: surrendering health, family duties or public resources for vanity can be irresponsible. The relevant test is what was sacrificed, whose interests bore the cost and whether the sacrifice was necessary and proportionate. Use it as a paper-attributed ethical proposition. (b) A Code of Ethics articulates the kind of public service an institution seeks: constitutional fidelity, selflessness, integrity, impartiality, empathy, openness, accountability and stewardship. It is necessary because detailed rules cannot foresee every dilemma or cultivate motive, judgment and leadership. It guides an officer facing a novel use of data or pressure that no clause fully anticipates. However, aspiration alone does not define an offence, competent authority, evidence, procedure or penalty. Treating a broad value such as 'courtesy' as automatic dismissal power would violate legality and due process. Enforceability arises only when a competent law, service rule, contract or House procedure incorporates a standard and supplies fair machinery. Ethics prevents misconduct; lawfully made conduct rules discipline it.

Q5. (a) "We can never obtain peace in the outer world until and unless we obtain peace within ourselves." - Dalai Lama. What does this quotation mean to you? (b) Differentiate the roles of the CVC, CBI and Lokpal in India's anti-corruption architecture.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (265 words; practice model, not official): (a) The quotation links external peace with internal emotional regulation. A person dominated by anger, fear, ego or prejudice carries those conflicts into public relationships; self-awareness and composure create the psychological space needed for listening, impartiality and non-violent problem-solving. For a district magistrate mediating communal tension, inner peace means recognising personal anxiety, resisting retaliatory language, hearing each community and communicating calmly under pressure. It improves credibility and prevents the official from escalating the conflict through impulsive action. Aristotle would describe this as habituated temperance supported by practical wisdom. Yet internal calm is only a precondition. Peace also requires justice, protection of rights, action against offenders and correction of structural grievances. Composure without substantive remedy can preserve an unjust status quo. The provenance should likewise be stated carefully: the exact wording is widely attributed but no primary source was verified. (b) The three institutions occupy connected but distinct positions. The CVC is a statutory vigilance body. It advises the Union system, exercises superintendence over DSPE corruption investigations within its specified remit and reviews vigilance administration; it does not adjudicate criminal guilt. The CBI is an investigating agency whose police powers derive from the DSPE Act. It gathers evidence within lawful territorial jurisdiction, while prosecution and the court complete later stages. Lokpal is the ombudsman created by the 2013 law for the Prime Minister subject to safeguards, Union Ministers, MPs, central officials and specified bodies. It may order preliminary inquiry and refer or direct investigation, including through CBI in appropriate cases. It complements rather than abolishes CVC and CBI. Role precision protects both effectiveness and due process.

Q6. Why is conduct that is legal not necessarily proper in public office? Illustrate.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (146 words; practice model, not official): Legality means conformity with enacted law; propriety asks whether conduct suits the responsibilities and the visible standing of the office. The gap matters because rules cannot enumerate every conflict, and

public confidence can be lost before any violation is proved. A district procurement officer may lawfully attend a private dinner hosted by a bidder where no payment or formal favour is established. The event can still create a reasonable apprehension of bias and compromise the officer's independence. The prudent response is disclosure, recusal where the nexus is direct, and avoidance of hospitality a citizen could fairly read as influence. Similar reasoning covers informal meetings, use of official information and public praise for connected firms. Propriety must not become vague policing of private life; it requires a nexus with office, entrusted power or public perception. Legal compliance is therefore the floor of public conduct, not its ceiling.

Q7. How does Kautilya's structural theory of official temptation remain relevant to designing modern anti-corruption controls in India?

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (139 words; practice model, not official): Kautilya's Arthashastra treats official corruption as structural rather than merely moral. The honey-and-poison passage (Kangle 2.9.32, cited in ARC Annexure-I(2)) argues that an official handling public funds can no more avoid temptation than a tongue can avoid tasting honey placed on it. Modern relevance: India's anti-corruption architecture operationalises this premise. Mandatory rotation of procurement officers assumes opportunity creates risk. Data-analytics-driven risk-based tax audit (CBDT) replaces discretionary scrutiny with algorithmic selection, assuming some non-compliance is structural. Dual-custody financial approvals prevent single-point failure. Kautilya also prescribes positive incentives: those who increase the king's wealth in just ways should be made permanent in office. This is an early performance-and-integrity-linked personnel policy. The limit: a purely surveillance-based regime risks demoralising honest officials through excessive suspicion. The ARC's synthesis pairs Kautilyan controls with Gandhian service-motivation to sustain both accountability and morale.

Q8. Vinod, an honest IAS officer and Managing Director of a State Road Transport Corporation after six transfers in three years, receives documents and a video alleging bribery by the politically powerful Chairman. The opposition source offers future career support, while exposure may cause another transfer. Evaluate Vinod's options and the ethical issues arising from politicisation of bureaucracy. Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (201 words; practice model, not official): Vinod can ignore the material, immediately publicise it, align with the opposition, confront the Chairman alone, or verify and route it institutionally. Ignoring credible evidence breaches fiduciary duty. Public disclosure may taint evidence and convert administration into partisan contest. Accepting promised advancement creates a fresh conflict even if the allegation is true. Solo confrontation risks destruction of records and retaliation. Vinod should acknowledge the source without accepting political terms, make a conflict record, secure copies and metadata, and order lawful discreet verification by a competent team. Procurement files, payment trails, tender criteria and communications should be preserved. If the threshold is met, he should refer the matter through the CVO or competent anti-corruption channel, recuse from any step creating personal conflict, and maintain confidentiality. He should document threatened transfer and seek review under applicable tenure policy while ensuring an institutional handover if moved. Politicisation produces transfer markets, partisan loyalty, selective exposure, policy discontinuity and public distrust. Its cure is not bureaucratic unaccountability but published posting criteria, fixed tenure with reasoned exceptions, board-level controls and independent investigation. Vinod must be non-partisan in method and fearless in substance. Evidence, not the documented electoral interest or the Chairman's proximity to power, should determine action.

Q9. Raman, a newly posted State Director General of Police, confronts online recruitment of unemployed youth by a global terrorist group. State intelligence indicates targeting of a particular community and extremist social-media activity. Examine his options, measures to strengthen the existing setup and an action plan for better intelligence gathering. Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (189 words; practice model, not official): Raman must act against a credible security threat without equating unemployment, community identity, dissent or heavy social-media use with terrorism. Options range from mass coercive action to passive monitoring; both extremes fail. Blanket profiling can alienate citizens, generate false positives and obscure actual recruiters, while delay permits mobilisation. He should establish a legally supervised, intelligence-led task force that verifies source reliability, maps recruiter networks and distinguishes advocacy, radical belief, preparation and criminal action. Targeted digital forensics should follow authorisation, necessity, proportionality, access controls and audit logs. Community leaders, educational bodies, employment agencies and mental-health or counselling services can support prevention and credible counter-messaging. At-risk youth should receive exit pathways rather than automatic criminal branding. The intelligence system needs trained analysts, multilingual capability, inter-agency fusion, source protection, false-positive review, periodic legal audit and independent complaint handling for abuse. Officers should record reasons for intrusive measures and supervisors should review discriminatory patterns. The ethics of honest-official protection applies to investigators too: clear rules and recorded approvals protect lawful decisions, while accountability

for fabrication, profiling or leakage prevents impunity. Raman's objective is precise prevention that protects both public safety and constitutional trust.

Q10. A district administrator discovers MGNREGA records showing non-payment to genuine workers, defective muster rolls, mismatch between work and payment, fictitious persons, fund siphoning and works that never existed. How should proper functioning be restored and what action should follow? Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (193 words; practice model, not official): The administrator should first protect workers and evidence. Freeze only suspect payment streams rather than the entire programme, secure muster rolls, sanction files, bank trails and measurement books, and arrange independent physical verification of works and beneficiary confirmation. Genuine pending wages and lawful employment demand should be restored through a controlled channel. A reconciliation should match job cards, attendance, measurements, payments, assets and bank accounts. Fictitious entries, connected officials and vendors, credential use and approval trails must be examined by a team independent of the implicated chain. A social audit and public hearing can add worker knowledge, but personal financial data should be protected. Findings should be classified as error, irregularity, fraud or suspected corruption rather than treated alike. Corrective action includes record repair, payment of dues, recovery where legally established, disciplinary or criminal referral through competent channels, and reasoned action-taken reports. Future prevention needs role separation, attendance and measurement controls, surprise field checks, exception alerts and safe complaints. The objective is simultaneous continuity of entitlement, evidence-based accountability and redesign of the conditions that enabled siphoning. The final decision should record reasons, safeguards, review points and a clear route for correcting foreseeable harm.

Q11. A State proposes an AI system to select welfare beneficiaries and a water-intensive data centre to operate it in a drought-prone district. As district head, resolve the combined data, justice and environmental dilemma. Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (241 words; practice model, not official): Stakeholders include eligible applicants, excluded families, local residents and farmers, tribal or marginalised groups, officials, the vendor, data-centre workers, the power and water utilities, the ecosystem and future citizens. The proposal promises faster targeting and jobs, but creates linked risks: biased exclusion, opaque reasons, privacy loss, vendor dependence, groundwater stress, energy emissions and unequal distribution of benefits and burdens. I would not approve immediate full-scale deployment. First, separate and test the two decisions. For beneficiary selection, define lawful eligibility, prohibit the model from making final adverse decisions, audit data and proxies, red-team vulnerable cases, provide notice, plain-language reasons, data correction, assisted offline application and timely human appeal. Contracts must assign accountability, preserve logs, permit independent audit and allow exit. Puttaswamy proportionality and purpose limitation govern personal-data use. For the data centre, commission a transparent assessment of water source, drought scenarios, energy, cooling, hardware and e-waste; compare less water-intensive locations and architectures; consult affected communities; and select the least-damaging feasible alternative. Approval, if justified, should impose water and carbon budgets, renewable additionality, non-potable or recycled water where safe, public monitoring, drought curtailment triggers and restoration security. Claimed welfare benefits cannot override ecological limits. A limited pilot using existing lower-impact infrastructure may proceed if independent review confirms rights and reliability safeguards. The final decision should publish reasons and residual risks. Innovation is acceptable only when beneficiaries can contest digital power and host communities do not subsidise it with dignity, water and future resilience.

Q12. A procurement officer receives a lawful-looking oral direction that would defeat the purpose of financial safeguards. Examine the ethical options and recommend a course of action. Address: (a) the stakeholders and competing duties; (b) the feasible options and their risks; and (c) the preferred course with safeguards and reasons.

[20 marks | 300 words]

Model answer (274 words; practice model, not official): The officer must separate apparent form from lawful substance. Relevant stakeholders include citizens financing the purchase, eligible vendors, the department, the superior, audit bodies and the officer. Ethical issues are value for money, conflict of interest, equality of opportunity, integrity of record, fear of retaliation and the risk that urgency becomes a pretext for favouritism. Blind compliance may preserve short-term hierarchy but can defeat financial purpose and damage trust. Public confrontation or unsupported accusation may be unfair and ineffective. Manipulating split orders or backdating records is clearly impermissible. The officer should first verify the applicable rule, delegated authority, urgency evidence and alternatives. She should seek written confirmation, place a neutral file note on the threshold and recommend a transparent, authorised procurement route. If the concern remains, she should escalate to the competent financial or vigilance authority, retaining evidence and avoiding public disclosure beyond necessity. A reasoned order should identify facts, legal authority, public purpose, comparable treatment and safeguards. Emergency departure, if legally authorised, must be narrow, time-bound, documented and reviewable. This solution respects hierarchy without treating obedience as superior to law, propriety or citizens' interest. It also

protects the officer through an audit trail and prescribed review of retaliatory appraisal or transfer. Finally, she should communicate respectfully, seek timely independent advice and distinguish a legitimate urgent exception from an instruction designed merely to avoid competition or oversight. This protects public trust. If emergency procurement is genuinely necessary, the file should state why ordinary competition was impracticable, identify the authorised exception, compare feasible alternatives and provide for post-facto scrutiny. This confines urgency to public purpose instead of letting it become a discretionary shield for favouritism.

Q13. You head a district welfare office that has introduced an automated system to rank applications for disability assistance. Complaints show that opaque data errors are excluding eligible citizens, while the vendor invokes trade secrecy and senior officials resist suspending a system praised for reducing pendency. A public disclosure could expose sensitive medical information, but continuing unchanged may deny urgent support. Identify the stakeholders and ethical conflicts, evaluate the available options, and recommend a lawful, transparent and time-bound course with safeguards and an appeal mechanism. Examine: (a) all material stakeholders; (b) the legal and ethical conflicts; (c) each realistic option and its consequences; and (d) the chosen course, implementation safeguards and review mechanism.

[30 marks | 350 words]

Model answer (229 words; practice model, not official): The central conflict is between administrative efficiency and equal, reasoned access to an entitlement. Stakeholders include applicants and families, field officials, medical authorities, the vendor, taxpayers, senior administrators and oversight bodies. Relevant values are dignity, non-discrimination, privacy, transparency, accountability and procedural fairness. Continuing unchanged is efficient but knowingly perpetuates exclusion. Immediate abandonment protects claimants but may revive delay and lose useful capacity. Unrestricted disclosure would aid scrutiny while violating medical privacy and legitimate security. The preferred course is a temporary human-review override for adverse decisions, notice of reasons in accessible language, a rapid appeal channel, and emergency provisional assistance where delay threatens subsistence. An independent technical and equality audit should test data quality and disparate impact. The contract should require regulator access to model logic, logs and performance evidence despite commercial confidentiality. Publish aggregate error rates and correction steps, not personal records. Resume automated rejection only after documented benchmarks, periodic audit and named official accountability are in place. The office should preserve every contested record, notify those previously rejected and conduct retrospective correction with arrears where entitlement was wrongly denied. A multidisciplinary review group including disability representatives should approve future changes. Procurement terms must allocate liability, prohibit unapproved secondary use of health data and permit termination for persistent bias. These measures retain useful automation while ensuring that legal responsibility remains with public officials rather than an opaque vendor system.

END OF DETAILED SOLUTIONS